

ected since the panel has reserved his constituency for Scheduled Castes (sc). Home Minister Shivraj Patil, who lost the 2004 election from Latur, may find his chances of winning the next elections from there bleaker than they were four years ago, with his constituency being reserved for sc. Chemicals Minister Ram Vilas Paswan, the hero of Hajipur, in Bihar, might also have to revise his political strategy as his constituency, so far reserved for sc, is now being dereserved. Railway Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav's constituency Chapra is expected to witness some changes while brother-in-law Sadhu Yadav's constituency Gopalganj would be reserved for sc. At the heart of the whole exercise is the

Chhattisgarh added 48 seats in state Assemblies since 2001 Census. There were 3,985 seats in state assemblies in the early 1970s when the last delimitation exercise was conducted based on the 1971 Census. Since then, 555 seats have been reserved for sc and 527 for st. The 2007 delimitation has enhanced seats for sc by 55 and those for st by 13 taking the total number of seats in assemblies to 4,033. The uneven rise in population among sc and st across states has resulted in the need for pulling out certain constituencies from the unreserved grouping. "The new delimitation orders are bound to affect certain established seats of different parties," BJP leader V.K. Malhotra said.

need to be distributed across states where their presence is large as compared to the total population. In case of st, seats are to be reserved only if their presence is the largest in the total population. Also, the panel has intended to correct an imbalance by downsizing certain constituencies like outer Delhi which has the highest number of electors (nationwide) at 3,368,399. Chandni Chowk, considered the smallest constituency at 10.59 sq km spread would become bigger.

Surveys and public hearings of the delimitation panel have suffered in the North-East because regional political parties continue to challenge the 2001 Census. "Indian voters first need to be identified from among illegal immi-

SUMEETINDER SINGH

PIYAL BHATTACHARJEE

SIPRA DAS

SIPRA DAS



JITIN PRASADA

SHAHJAHANPUR

The Congress MP's seat is proposed to be reserved for SC.



SACHIN PILOT

DAUSA

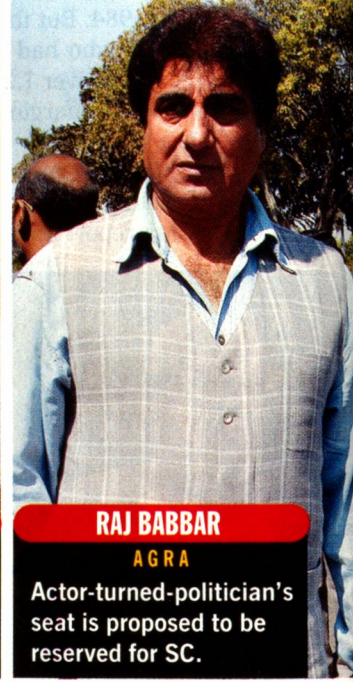
The Pilot family's hold over the constituency may end if it is moved into ST category.



SADHU YADAV

GOPALGANJ

Lalu Prasad's brother-in-law's writ may not run if the seat is reserved for SC.



RAJ BABBAR

AGRA

Actor-turned-politician's seat is proposed to be reserved for SC.

reservation of parliamentary and assembly constituencies for sc and st. Of the 545 seats in Lok Sabha, two are for nominated members from Anglo-Indian community. Of the 543 seats for which elections are held, 79 are reserved for sc and 41 for st, leaving 423 seats in the general category. If the elections for the 15th Lok Sabha, due in 2009, are held under the new delimitation norms, there will be an increase of six seats in the sc category and seven in the st category, thereby reducing the general seats to 410.

State assemblies are also not untouched by reservation. Creation of Uttarakhand, Jharkhand and

Chief Election Commissioner N. Gopalaswami believes the next Lok Sabha elections would be held on the basis of the new delimitation guidelines. "Certain people are apprehensive of the reservation of seats but the panel gave parties and voters the right to express themselves through public hearings," he told INDIA TODAY. Since it was formed in 2003, Delimitation Commission has worked on setting boundaries of constituencies on the basis of the 2001 Census. The aim is to distribute the population among constituencies within a 10 per cent margin. Section 9(1)(d) of the Delimitation Act, 2002, stipulates that seats for sc

grants from neighbouring countries there," Arun Sharma, Assam Gana Parishad MP from Assam, said. The Gauhati High Court had asked the panel and the Centre to stop the exercise in Assam, Nagaland, Arunachal Pradesh and Manipur, following a large number of petitions made against the move. The Supreme Court has now stepped in, quashing the high court orders pertaining to Nagaland, Manipur and Arunachal Pradesh. The delimitation panel hopes to resolve the problem in Assam with the apex court's help.

Politicians should not complain about a change in the system once every 30 years.